

A phrase is a group of words that act as a single ,grammatical unit within a sentence but does not form a complete sense, because it does not have a subject and a finite verb.

A Noun Phrase is a group of two or more words that function as a noun in a sentence, consisting of a noun or pronoun and its modifiers.

(a) Noun Phrase: In a noun phrase, the head word must be a noun or pronoun.

A noun phrase can be replaced by a pronoun.

Examples:

(i) ...the village headmaster.

(ii) at the gate

(iii) The old woman sleeping in the room

(iv) the broken bottle.

(v) I gave the money

(vi) To sleep without light is frightening.

Vii. Reading at night.....

Functions of Noun Phrase

Like noun, noun phrase has six different grammatical functions:

sentence, it functions as

subject of the verb that follows it.

Examples:

(i) Sleeping without light is not something I enjoy.

Function: subject of the verb is

(ii) The beautiful girl comes here everyday.

Function: subject of the verb comes

2. Subject Complement: When the noun phrase is the same thing or person as the subject, it functions as subject complement.

(i) Olu is the doctor (the doctor is the same person as Olu).

(ii) The mystery is that the boy can write at his age .

Function: subject complement "mystery"

3. Object of the Verb: When the noun phrase comes after a verb in the sentence, it functions as object of the verb.

Examples:

(i) I gave the money to the best student.

the money is the object of the verb gave

(ii) Akpan received an award for excellence.

An award is the object of the verb received

4. Object Complement: When the noun phrase follows the object, it functions as the object complement. called the something silly before

Examples:

(i) I gave Sola the money.

-the money completes the meaning of Sola who is given the money
therefore it functions as the object complement.

(ii) They called the former ruler a tyrant.

- a tyrant completes the object the former ruler

5. Complement of a Preposition: When the noun phrase occurs after a preposition, it is governed by the preposition. Hence, it is the object of the preposition.

Examples:

*(1) Award of excellence was given to the zonal manager.

(2) Under the bed is where I lost my keys.

(3) After lunch is the best time for nap.

6. In Apposition to a noun: A noun phrase is said to be in apposition to a noun when the noun phrase and the noun refer to the same person or thing. For example, in the sentence: 'Umar

Yar'Adua, the president of Nigeria, has travelled to China,'

the noun phrase the president of Nigeria is in apposition to the noun Umar

Yar'Adua since they refer to the same person.

Example:

(i) Nigeria, the oil-rich giant of Africa, attained independence in 1960.

-The underlined noun phrase is in apposition to the noun Nigeria.